

MORE TEMPO WORDS AND THEIR MEANINGS

Term	Meaning
A tempo	as before (for instance, following <i>ritenuto</i>)
Tempo primo	original tempo
Rubato	varying the tempo in a controlled way

MODIFYING WORDS AND THEIR MEANINGS

Term	Meaning
Poco	a little
Molto	very
Più	more
Poco a poco	gradually

TEMPO WORDS WITH EXPRESSIVE MEANINGS

Term	Meaning
Allegretto	fairly fast, but often implying “lightly”
Grave	slow and solemn
Largo	slow, broad
Allargando	slower, broader
Vivace	fast, very lively, spirited

< **Modifying words**

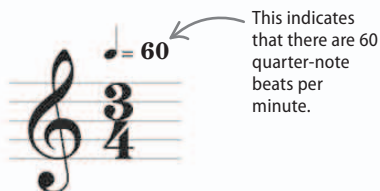
These are widely used alongside other tempo words—for instance, “Più allegro.”

△ **Tempo plus expression**

Some tempo words may express something about the spirit of the music as well as how fast it should be played.

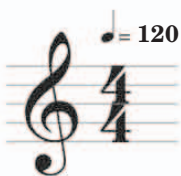
Metronome marks

How fast is “fast” or “allegro”? A more precise way of indicating the tempo is by specifying the number of beats per minute. These indications are called “metronome marks.” They are written at the start of a score, above the time signature, and can also be added at other places where the tempo changes (like text instructions).

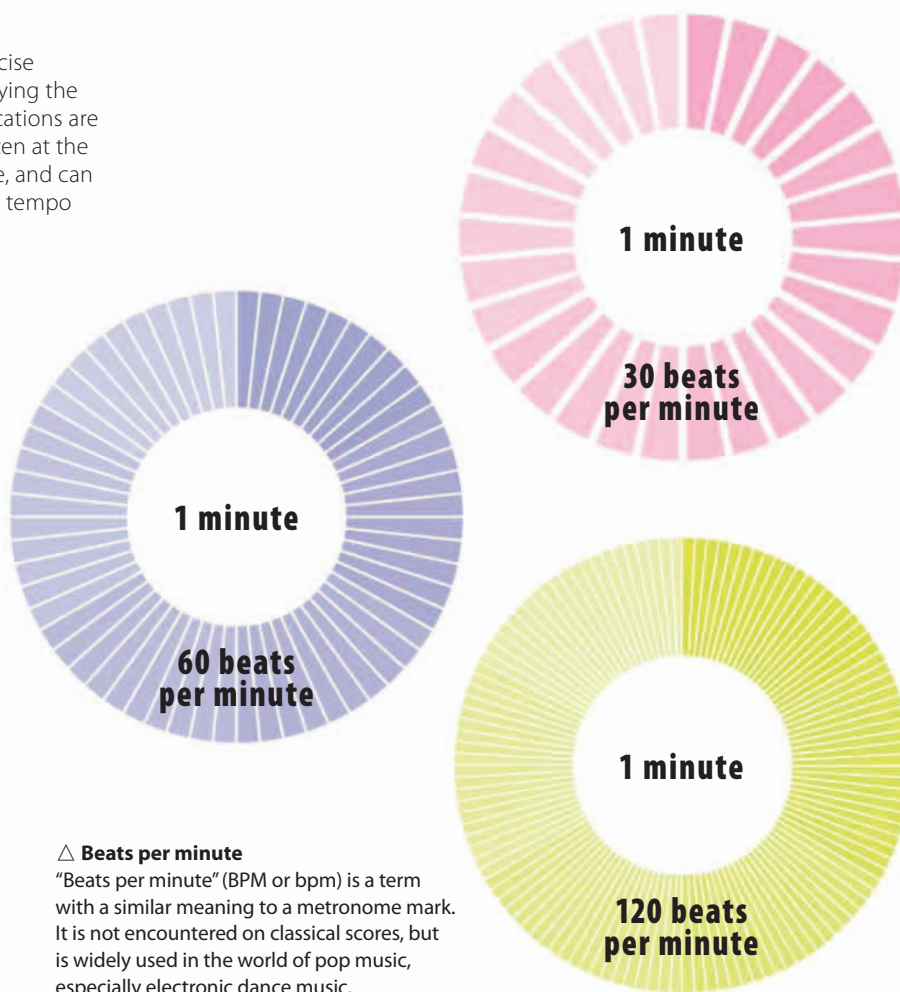
△ **Metronome mark position**

Metronome marks are written above the time signature, where they are most needed.

Allegro

△ **Metronome marks with text**

Metronome marks are often combined with other forms of tempo indication, such as text instructions.

△ **Beats per minute**

“Beats per minute” (BPM or bpm) is a term with a similar meaning to a metronome mark. It is not encountered on classical scores, but is widely used in the world of pop music, especially electronic dance music.